

Three Cs for Evaluating Sources

Use this framework to quickly evaluate a potential source. Let the questions below guide you, but don't answer all of them!

FULL CITATION

Sample student note.

Creator

Who created this source? Is an author or authorial group identified? What are the creator's academic and/or professional credentials? Are they a recognized expert in their field? Who or what makes them an authority? Is the creator affiliated with institutions or organizations? What other connections are revealed by a cursory search?

Sample student note.

Content

Does the content provide ample attributions and citations? Are its sources easy to locate and verify? How does this information square with your prior knowledge about and other sources on the subject? Is it reasonable? How is the material written and organized? Whom is it addressing? What questions does it strive to answer? What positions does it take? When was the content last updated? When was it first created?

Sample student note.

Context

Where, why, how, and by whom was this content disseminated? Who funded its creation? Where and how did you find it? What other materials exist alongside it? Can you locate reviews of the content or its creator? Why does it exist? Whose agenda(s) does it serve?

Sample student note.